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Velu Chinnasamy at the reading corner in the shop. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND

Residents say the transformation has had a wider impact. Amudha, a teenager, says she now looks forward to accompanying her grandmother to the shop because of the books. Ponni, a nearby flower vendor, says cleaner surroundings have brought more customers to the area. Teacher and resident Radha Seshadri says the initiative reflects the belief that books can shape lives, echoing former President A. P. J. Abdul Kalam's words on the value of reading.

lapuram, Kovalam, and Redhills. Commuters want the information boards in English as well. One can access the information on MTC X's page, Instagram, and Facebook.



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Fix pavements on First Main Road in Nanganallur

R. VASUDEVAN

The Alandur Zone of the Greater Chennai Corporation (Zone 12) should fix the slabs on pavements on First Main Road in Nanganallur. Most of the slabs on the pavements are broken or missing, posing a risk to pedestrians.

Outside a Public Distribution System (PDS) outlet, consumers are at risk of falling. Further, the pavements need to be cleaned. The manhole lids on the pavement are broken, and the rusted lids should be removed.

As a result, pedestrians are forced to walk on the road, sharing space with motorists because vehicles are parked along the pavements.

R. Vasudevan is a resident of Nanganallur



Broken pavements on First Main Road in Nanganallur.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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‘More needs to be done to prevent trespassing’

S. LAKSHMI SUBRAMANIAN

Recently, Southern Railway installed boards along the tracks at Tambaram railway station to warn public that crossing the tracks is strictly prohibited.

Passengers and pedestrians cross the tracks to board trains and to go to Tambaram (East and West). To prevent people from walking through the tracks, Southern Railway has to take a series of steps.

Commuters from Tambaram (East) walk through Mathew Colony, a railway residential area, and through the building premises in which power and battery storage rooms are located, to the tracks.

Public from Tambaram (West) come from platform 1A, a double-discharge platform towards Chennai Beach, cross the tracks to board trains and to Tambaram (East) through the Colony.

The railway must deploy Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel in the area (at two en-



trances) and on the building premises to prevent public from gaining access to the tracks.

The public does this to avoid negotiating a series of steps in the footbridge.

The long-distance trains' platforms at the station do not have either lifts or escalators, unlike at the platforms for trains towards Chennai Beach, Chengalpattu, Tirumalpur, Kancheepuram, and Arakonam.

Southern Railway should install escalators and lifts along the entrances (East and West) and at the long-distance train platforms.

S. Lakshmi Subramanian is a resident of East Tambaram



The board installed at Tambaram railway station; and people walking through the tracks at the station. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chromepet needs a bigger playground

R. RAMADASS

The State Government should allot space for a cricket and football ground in Chromepet (East). At present, Periyar Vilayattu Thidal at Bharathipuram in Chromepet is thronged by children. On week-days, about 500 youngsters play on the ground, which spreads across 1 to 1.5 acres.

There is a need for a bigger playground. Behind the Institute of Road Transport in Chromepet is a vast ground measuring around 20 acres. Around two decades ago, students used to play on the ground; now, this space is enclosed by walls and marked by thorny plants.

Sections of the ground can be used to create cricket and football fields. This will prevent youngsters from falling prey to bad habits and help them improve their physique.

R. Ramadass is a resident of Chromepet



Youngsters play cricket at Periyar Vilayattu Thidal in Bharathipuram, Chromepet. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Halt all buses at Kilambakkam stopover’

D. MALARVIZHI DAMODARAN

Metropolitan Transport Corporation should halt all route number buses at Kilambakkam terminus in GST Road (on the lane towards Vandalur).

Recently, to go to Maduravoyal, I boarded 500P, a white board service, plying from Chengalpattu to Pallavaram, at Mahindra World City haltover.

From Kalaingar Centenary Bus Terminus in Kilambakkam, I can board 104C, touching Maduravoyal. As the buses from Chengalpattu, Guduvancherry, and Maraimalai Nagar, do not halt at the haltover, I got down at Vandalur stop and boarded the route number bus.

When bus routes such as 91V, E18, G18, 500, 118 and 500P (heading to Guduvancherry, Chengalpattu and Maraimalai Na-

gar) enter and exit the terminus, why cannot the the buses from Maraimalai Nagar, Guduvancherry, and Chengalpattu follow the same?

Commuters from Urapakkam have to walk or take an auto to reach the terminus or the Vandalur haltover. The drivers have to take a U-turn at the Vandalur junc-

tion, opposite the regional wildlife park.

At present, a section of MTC drivers from the terminus halt on compassionate grounds, thereby alleviating the woes of commuters and long-distance passengers.

D. Malarvizhi Damodaran is a resident of Chettipuniyam, near Mahindra World City



Kalaingar Centenary Bus Terminus in Kilambakkam.
PHOTO: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

'Barricade this stretch of First Main Road'

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Nanganallur residents have made a request to the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board to barricade a section of First Main Road until the basic infrastructure work is completed.

Work is currently under way to replace the old underground sewer pipes on the stretch.

N. Hariharan, a long-time resident of Nanganallur and a social activist, says, "After the work commenced, only motorcyclists were allowed to proceed from First Main Road to Vanuvampet region and vice versa. But due to poor monitoring, the section witnesses heavy vehicular traffic, including heavy vehicles and wrong-side driving too."

Motorists drive in the wrong lane, halting traffic from Vanuvampet. To avoid collisions with their counterparts, the motorists jump



Traffic congestion is a regular occurrence on First Main Road in Nanganallur due to poor compliance with traffic rules.

lanes, posing danger to vehicle users taking a left turn from Second Main Road to First Main Road.

On First Main Road, towards Fourth Main Road, drivers from Second Main Road come in the wrong

direction at high speed, increasing the risk of collisions with those coming from Vanuvampet. Along the work site, vehicle users from First Main Road and Vanuvampet come at a clip, increasing the risk of

accidents, Hariharan points out.

R. Vidhya Ramanujam, a motorist, says, "Because of the work machine, the view is blocked for pedestrians crossing the road and for motorists from Vanuvampet. To

avoid accidents, it is better to close a section of the road. Until this is done, traffic police are a must in the evenings. Senior citizens with eye problems are the most affected and are at risk of accidents."

Premises outside Guindy stations lit up



Following a report in these pages dated April 5 about lighting up areas outside Guindy electric and metro stations, social activist P. Sathyanarayanan says CMRL installed LED lights. The reader wrote about the need for a pay-and-use facility outside the stations.

RWA in Chromepet celebrates silver jubilee



V. Santhanam addresses residents. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

To mark its silver jubilee, San-karlal Jain Street Residents Welfare Association in Chromepet conducted traditional games, indoor and outdoor sports, music, dance, and oth-

er cultural performances, creating a festive and inclusive atmosphere throughout the street. V. Santhanam, social activist and a long-time resident of The New Colony in

Chromepet, and Dr S. Muthukumar of Parvathy Hospital participated and distributed prizes to the winners. Residents hosted a dinner for 200 people.

Volunteers urge WRD to carry out proper restoration work

After forming bunds and using the excess excavated silt to create islands at Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, the Water Resources Department has not cleared a mound of chemical soil in the lake area.

Volunteers at Thiruneermalai Periya Eri Padhukappu Kuzhu, a lake restoration volunteer group, have requested that the Water Resources Department remove soil contaminated with chemicals resulting from sewage inflows and years of garbage dumping, to store rainwater.

B. Saravanan, a core volunteer in

the group, says, "If the Water Resources Department does not remove the soil, there is no use in restoring the lake. The water will get contaminated and pose a health hazard to people."

"Secondly, in the southern part of the lake, there is a quarry with water hyacinth. If the quarry is cleared of water hyacinth and restored, water can be stored, and after filtering, it can be fed into the lake or distributed to the public through pipelines. If this is not followed, the structures on the lake will be flooded."

Sanitary staff honoured on May Day

Chitlapakkam Anna Nagar (West) Residents Welfare Association celebrated May Day in a grand manner.

S. Chandrasekaran, secretary of the association and its office bearers, distributed groceries to 100 sanitary staff from Wards 34, 43 and 44 (Chitlapakkam region) of the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation.

Subashini Purushothaman, councillor, Ward 34, and Jagan and Raja of Wards 43 and 44 respectively, were present. The association requested that the councillors of these Wards take steps to facilitate welfare measures, provide toilets and



washbasins, gloves and raincoats, medical facilities, conduct medical camps at regular intervals, and also provide education for their children.

An everyday utility created with metal discards

Integrating rice mill and automobile scrap material, a resident of Manimangalam panchayat creates a garbage unit that combines functionality, aesthetics and nostalgia



A view of the installation at Gurukul Street in Manimangalam; during Mattu Pongal the installation is decorated.

PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

PRINCE FREDERICK

Experiences in late childhood and early adulthood stick fast and long like cyanoacrylate, and would sometimes go on to be fodder for creativity. That is plain, observed logic. But if you are a pedant given to swallowing something only if it arrives with a saccharine coating of high-sounding concepts, here they are for you.

'Schema Theory' and 'Reminiscence Bump', both from psychology, explain this form of creativity. A 38-year-old architect displaying no signs of pedantry, M. Dilli Babu explains his *creation artistique* as

plainly as possible in any human language. "What I saw as a child I have recreated."

What did he see?

Garbage being picked by carts drawn by oxen. At panchayats in distinctly rural settings, around three decades ago, one could expect garbage being gathered in a cart pulled by an ox. Manimangalam now might be in the peri-urban bracket, but is still a village panchayat in administrative terms, and back when Dilli Babu was a child, draft animals, precisely oxen, would have been on the conservancy team.

And what did he recreate?

A functional garbage cart paired

to an ox, the whole shebang created with upcycled materials. The installation is plonked at the entrance of Gurukul Street in Manimangalam, where Dilli Babu also has his house. Garbage is dumped and cleared. The installation is a head turner, something this writer can vouch for from personal experience, having stopped to take a long look at it while on the way to somewhere else.

Six years ago, when he got started on this project, Dilli Babu sought permission from the Manimangalam panchayat to repurpose a cart lying at the panchayat office unused and in a state of oblivion.

Chewed away, the garbage col-

lection unit had to have sheets welded into it, wheels replaced. The cart was paired with a bull, and the exercise drew upon a slew of material from the rice-grinding equipment that were past their usefulness in the rice mill.

Dilli Babu's brother runs a rice mill, which made discarded materials from there the automatic choice for the sustainability project. Running a construction company named DB Architect, Dilli Babu could repurpose old construction material. Bent TMT rods define the contours of the ox. Motorcycle and cycle parts are unmistakable, despite being seamlessly blended into the *objet d'art* with efficient welding and painting. Suspension parts from a Tata 407 truck have also made a handsome contribution to the design.

Dilli Babu points out the rear section can be removed, facilitating easy garbage clearance. The cart can be lifted in a manner comparable to how a traditional cart can be

lifted and kept lifted after unharnessing the ox.

The garbage cart had a two-in-one functionality thrust into it with a 200-litre water tank being placed in the "innards" of the ox. The water could be accessed through a tap. The practice of filling the tank and offering it as an additional utility was discontinued when visitors from a Tasmac outlet nearby make the site of the garbage cart a pit stop, thanks to the availability of drinking water, says Dilli Babu.

With an explicit bovine connection, the installation is swept into Mattu Pongal celebrations every year. Prior to the event, it is not just bedecked with glitzy decorative items, but also put through a wringer of maintenance work and repairs.

The installation would have been fuelled by nostalgia, but it is nostalgia that scratches below the surface of feel-good sensation to surface something of immense everyday utilitarian value.



Serving strangers in Velachery

At AGS Colony in Velachery the residents are coming together to care for those on the streets. For over eight years, a daily buttermilk distribution near Hindu Vidyalaya has been serving conservancy workers, delivery staff, passengers and MTC bus crews during hours when the mercury shoots up.

Between 10 a.m. and 11:30 a.m. every day, nearly 70 litres of buttermilk is distributed, reaching around 250 to 300 people. The effort is sustained entirely through local participation. "Participation is by the entire community," says Upendra Sai, District President, Chennai South East. "Some residents bring curd, some bring water and many come forward to serve." Children are at the heart of the initiative. "This is primarily done by Balavikas children aged 6 to 15. The idea is to inculcate

The COOL crew

As temperatures rise across Chennai, resident welfare associations in several neighbourhoods are stepping up summer relief efforts for conservancy workers, delivery personnel and other essential staff through drinking water kiosks and buttermilk distribution

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

the value of service in them," he explains, with adults supporting the preparation. The impact is visible in small but telling ways—buses pause briefly so passengers can have a drink, and nearby institutions extend support. Contributions are pooled in kind. "No single person is funding it. Each interested person contributes whatever they can," Sai adds.

An everyday thing in Semmancherry

At the gated community Navin's Marisdale in Semmancherry, care for essential workers is not limited to peak summer, but built into its everyday functioning.

"Our Association takes great pride in fostering a warm, supportive, and inclusive environment," says secretary Muruganantham. One of the more distinctive efforts involves recycling: scrap collected from residents is sold, and the money is "reinvested with care" into staff welfare—covering tea, coffee, buttermilk during summer and



even occasional treats like biriyani.

The support extends to what the campus itself produces. "Coconut, guava, pomegranate and banana are shared with our staff," he says,

referring to security guards, gardeners and sanitation workers. Any surplus is sold, with proceeds again routed back into welfare.

With summer intensifying, practical steps have been added. "Water is essential—unlimited drinking water is always accessible," he notes. Staff and the sanitation workers are also offered watermelon and tender coconut during the season. Importantly, work hours are adjusted: "They can come early and leave before the scorching heat."

"Coming from middle-class backgrounds ourselves, we understand their needs," Muruganantham adds. "Even small gestures can bring genuine happiness."

The mud pot: a symbol of care in Mandaveli



In Mandaveli, on Raja Street, next to the local PHC, residents have placed a mud pot filled with drinking water outside their apartment. It is accessible throughout the day to delivery agents, vendors, conservancy workers and visitors waiting at the clinic. Between 11:45 a.m. and 12:30 p.m., residents also distribute buttermilk, rose milk or nan-nari sharbat. The initiative, which began in April, will continue through May or until the summer loses its edge. Around 25 people benefit daily during this window. "We started this keeping the summer heat in mind. Many of them

are out on the streets for long hours," says Ganga Sridhar of the Mandaveli Raja Street Residents Welfare Association. "Now, some even time their rounds to stop here. That shows it's useful."

The effort is supported by a small group of resident donors and coordinated by apartment members and watchmen. On May 1, the association marked Labour Day with a one-day meal distribution for over 50 workers, including domestic helpers, vendors, and security staff. "It is a way of acknowledging the people who keep our daily lives running," a resident says.

An 'oasis' in Perungalathur

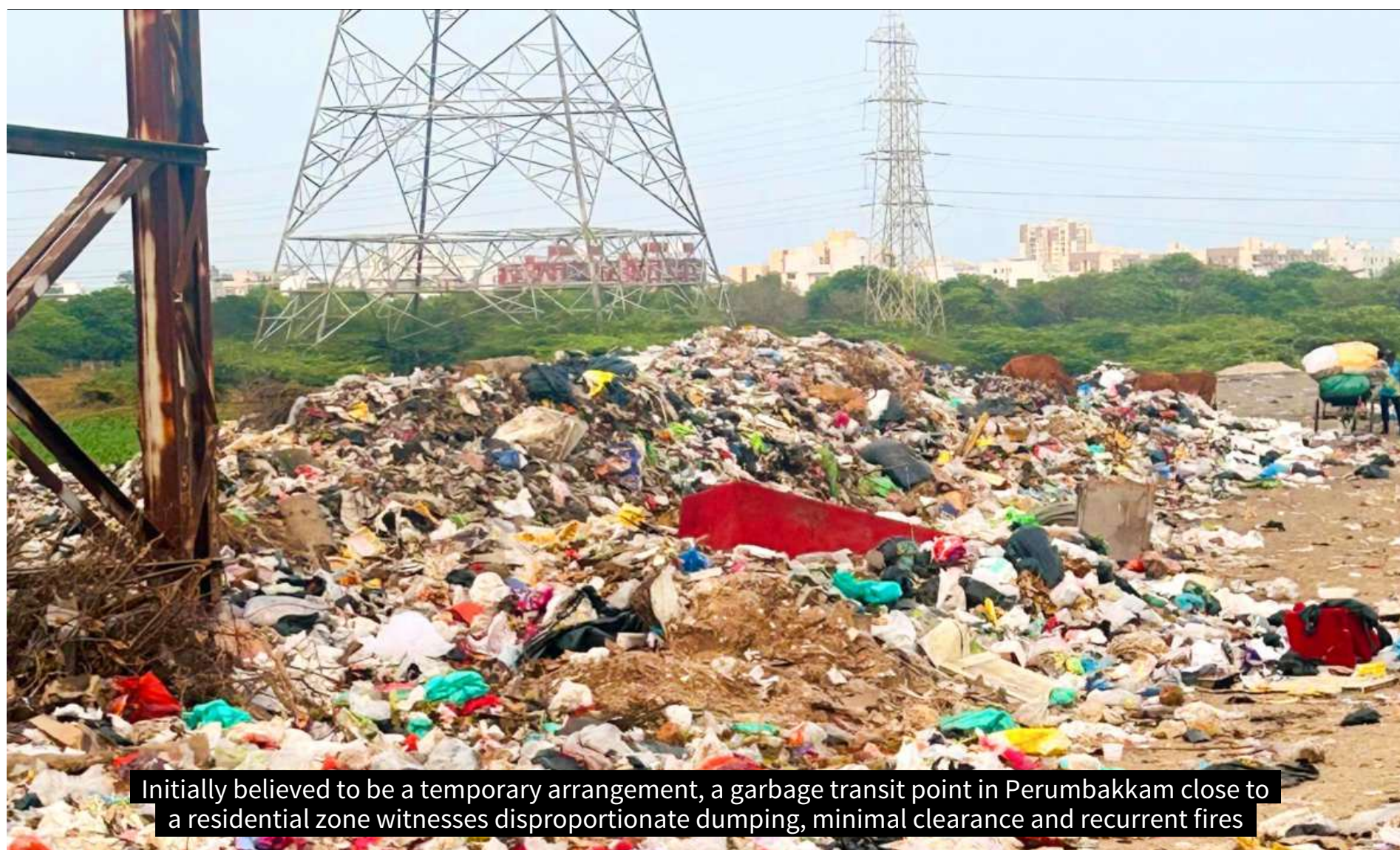


At SSM Nagar in Perungalathur, now in its fourth year, the initiative began with a simple observation: construction workers, delivery personnel, and daily wage labourers often had to buy drinking water or go without it.

"We found people buying water or asking for it during summer, and felt, as an association, we could start keeping water here," recalls Saravanan Kuppuswamy, former Secretary of SSMNFOA.

From a single water kiosk, the initiative has grown into a network of three strategically placed points across the neighbourhood. Each is replenished daily by a dedicated vendor, with association members and volunteers closely monitoring both quantity and quality. "Every day, the pots are filled. If it gets over, we ensure it is replenished immediately," he says.

The programme has since expanded to include evening buttermilk distribution, supported by Akshayakalpa. Between 4 p.m. and 5.30 p.m., dozens of people gather, from children returning from play to workers on their way home. "It is not about numbers but it is about making sure anyone who is thirsty is taken care of," he adds.



Initially believed to be a temporary arrangement, a garbage transit point in Perumbakkam close to a residential zone witnesses disproportionate dumping, minimal clearance and recurrent fires

PRINCE FREDERICK

Garbage dump *fire chokes* residential zone

In apartments, buyers pay not only for a living space, but also for its relative attractiveness. How it compares with the other spaces in the apartment matters; its relation to the surrounding environment, the one outside the community, is also of significance. Pardon the real-estate jargon, the cost gets bumped up on account of floor rise charges (FRC).

The farther you leave *terra firma* behind and the closer you get to the skies, the greater the amount you pay for the living pad. The view from the higher floors can be arresting. The promise of better air quality can tip the scales in favour of a higher-floor dwelling unit when it concerns a family that has a senior with COPD or any other respiratory problem.

But in urban and peri-urban spaces, that advantage can be rudely nullified, sometimes with a suddenness that could leave one stumped.

On the evening of May 1, from his dwelling unit on the 14th floor, 35-year-old Ananta Charan Swain was left breathless, not by the view, but the smoke engulfing his living space in the skies.

"It was heavy smoke; it affected everyone, young as well as the old," Ananta recalls. He points out that over the last six to seven months, from time to time, resi-

dents of Casa Grand First City, a vertical gated community, 1,680 units spread across multiple blocks, have been treated to a blast of smoke, rising from a garbage fire uncomfortably close to their community.

Ananta notes this problem crops up almost every two weeks, sometimes the fire smoulders on for days, emitting smoke.

The recent fire was one such; it reportedly began around 10 a.m. on April 29, and continued for days.

Ananta shares the garbage dumping site is situated just outside the gated community, painfully close to its Open Space Reservation area, approximately 20 to 30 metres away. A large park is located on this OSR area. On the other side, the Perumbakkam bus depot is located.

He elaborates that initially, the Perumbakkam panchayat officials had promised that the site would

be a garbage transit point. No sooner would the garbage be dumped than it would be cleared: that was part of the promise. Besides, it would be a temporary arrangement, and the exercise shifted out once a permanent garbage transit point was identified. Constraints in having another space as a garbage transit point had led the panchayat to settle on this one. As it turned out, the dumping of garbage was massively disproportionate to its clearance. What is worse, residents are getting a disturbing sense of permanence about this garbage dumping site.

The stench gets the residents, even those on the higher floors, and every two weeks, things take a turn for the worse with smoke reaching them too.

The smoke on the evening of May 1 was particularly alarming. Residents like Ananta returning home reported being unable to breathe comfortably. Smoke had spread extensively, forcing people to shut their doors and windows. He says the negative impact was felt even in distant areas, reportedly those around Global Hospital.

Ananta also underlines the wider environmental ramifications of having this site as a garbage transit point. It is not too far from the "doorsteps" of the Perumbakkam wetland, which is considered part of the Pallikaranai marsh ecosystem. A canal is also located near the dumping site.



The garbage transit point; and (below) the fire that raged there on April 29.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



During the awards ceremony; and (below) a view of the campus.

Sustainability award for school in Kelambakkam

Chettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School, located within the ecologically rich 108-acre Chettinad Health City in OMR, Kelambakkam, has been recognised by Earthday.org for its commitment to sustainability practices, a milestone that reflects years of deeply rooted environmental action woven into the school's very identity.

According to a press release, founded in 2017 as a Cambridge International School offering both day and residential facilities, Sarvalokaa has long believed that education and environmental stewardship belong together.

The school operates within a Net-Zero, All-Electric, closed-loop campus, generating 51% of its energy through solar and wind, treating and reusing 83% of its daily wastewater, maintaining zero groundwater dependency, and absorbing up to 60 tonnes of CO₂ annually through its dense native forest cover spanning 5.8 acres of native flora and a thriving three-acre man-

go forest.

The press release adds that the campus is entirely free of motor vehicles, operating instead through walking and cycling pathways that create a silent, clean, and healing environment for learners. A zero-waste circular ecosystem, supported by seven composting units and a strict no-plastic policy, ensures that the school's ecological footprint remains minimal.

But beyond infrastructure, it is the children who make this recognition truly meaningful. From growing food seed-to-plate and caring for animals to building bug hotels, creating natural rangoli, and learning barefoot amidst nature, Sarvalokaa's learners live it every single day. The school's nature-inspired curriculum transforms the campus itself into a living classroom.

This Earthday.org recognition joins a growing list of acknowledgements for Sarvalokaa, the release adds.

For more information, visit www.sarvalokaa.org



Swetha Anand elected as president of CREGU India

The India chapter of Centro Di Ricerca Sull'Educazione Dei Giovani Per L'UNESCO (CREGU), a centre based in Italy dedicated to advancing youth education and research, has inducted Swetha Sundeep Anand as its national president for UNESCO Youth Education Research Center in India. The induction ceremony was held at Bharath Institute of Science and Technology in Tambaram. The induction ceremony was officiated by Melisa Aysegil Gal, head of the Secretariat of CREGU, who was the chief guest.

Melisa Aysegil Gal delivered a keynote address on 'Youth Voices on Sustainable Development Goals', emphasising the transformative role of young people as active contributors and leaders in advancing the United Nations Sus-



tainable Development Goals.

The induction of Swetha Anand represents a key milestone in strengthening CREGU India's mission to promote youth education, interdisciplinary research, and capacity-building initiatives aligned with global development priorities, said a release.



You can be our volunteer writer

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Chennai Super Mom on May 10

The 13th edition of Chennai Super Mom will be held on May 10 at Ampa Skyone Aminjikarai; 3 p.m. onwards.

Organised by IRIS Events, this year a special segment will feature moms who are

above 50 and their inspiring journeys.

Other highlights include 'Parambarya Samayal', a fun cooking contest where moms create innovative snacks and present them with a unique slogan; and 'Mom & Me', a

bonding segment with mother-child fashion walk, fitness activities, and a parenting debate.

Last day to register is May 6. Instagram @irisevents2000 For details, call 9884783510, 9841206506



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Chennai residents, take cleanliness survey seriously now

With citizen feedback for Swachh Survekshan having begun, animators are reaching out to various groups seeking that individuals answer a set of 13 questions. Chennai is believed to have been doing poorly in this annual assessment partly due to its residents' reluctance to take the survey

LIFFY THOMAS

If you are stopped by an animator, a professional in Greater Chennai Corporation ranks, and asked to take part in a cleanliness survey of the city then do spare a few minutes for them.

The Citizen Feedback for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan is on and every input by a resident slipped into the online system will help determine where Chennai stands among cities in terms of its cleanliness quotient.

The survey is not just about rankings but improving people's quality of life, which makes public participation significant.



Citizen participation is the cornerstone of the initiative, with 35% of the total percentage of marks allotted based on what its people have to say about various initiatives taken by the city corporations. However, over the years, what has put Chennai at a disadvantage is poor residents' participation in the process.

"This time, we have set a target of reaching at least five lakh people in Chennai," says a member with the IEC team.

Animators are reaching out to college students, anganwadi staff, teachers and bulk waste generators explaining the processes that go behind this ranking and requesting them to take

part in the exercise.

Two of the city's main waste management companies, Urbaser Sumeet and Ramky, are also helping out in this exercise by reaching out to communities they are working with.

Citizen Feedback 2026 requires residents to answer 13 simple questions related to sanitation, waste collection, public toilets and the performance of local authorities. One has to complete the survey on their own as an OTP is generated for every submitted feedback.

Posts on its social media handles are expected to start coming once election results are out, nudging citizens to take part, says the staff.



Animators request a resident to take part in the survey and (right) outside a textile showroom.

The method
* Direct link
cf.sbmurban.org
* Download
Swachhata App

Cancellation of EMU train services

To facilitate engineering work on the Chennai Central - Arakkonam Section, Arakkonam Yard, the following electrical multiple units and mainline electrical multiple units will be partially cancelled until May 16.

Train Numbers: 43411, Moore Market Complex - Arakkonam at 11 a.m. between Tiruvalangadu and Arakkonam, 43512, Tiruttani - Moore Market Complex at 12:35 p.m. between Tiruttani and Tiruvalangadu, and 66009, Moore Market Complex - Arakkonam MEMU passenger at 22.55 p.m. between Tiruvalangadu and Arakkonam.

CMRL discontinues travel card

To completely switchover to the Chennai Card - National Common Mobility Card, as per Government of India guidelines, the Chennai Metro Rail Limited has decided to discontinue its travel card, from May 1.

The decision has been taken to enable seamless travel in public transports across the country.

For further usage in metro trains or at metro parking areas, the commuters should transfer the remaining value in the travel card to QR Stored Value Pass (SVP) purchased through CMRL mobile app or National Common Mobility Card.

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